

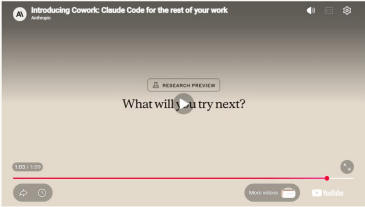
Estimated time: 8 minutes

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson you'll be able to:

- Define Claude Cowork and explain what makes it a different way of working with Claude
- Understand Cowork as Claude working in your environment — on your files, in your apps, with your tools
- Tell Chat, Cowork, and Code apart, and know which to reach for when

Introducing Cowork



This video introduces Claude Cowork and the type of work it's built to do. Notice how Cowork functions: not as a smarter chatbot, but as a different way of working with Claude entirely.

Key takeaways

- Cowork is Claude built for the work, not just the answer. It meets you where you work — whether it's local on your machine, cloud apps, or your browser.
- Cowork is about delegating. Chat is still where you go to think out loud, draft, or ask. Cowork adds something new: the ability to describe an outcome and have Claude plan, execute, and deliver the whole thing.
- Cowork is built for multi-step, longer-running work. Tasks that span several tools, take a while to complete, and end in a real artifact — Cowork is designed to handle that whole arc end-to-end.
- You stay in control. Claude shows you its plan before it starts, by default asks before it takes actions that matter (sending, deleting, sharing), and lets you steer at any point.

What Cowork actually is

Cowork is a mode of Claude inside the desktop app where Claude works on tasks alongside you. You point it at a folder on your computer, connect the apps where your work lives (Gmail, Slack, Google Drive, your calendar), and describe what you want done. Claude makes a plan, works through the steps, uses the tools and files it needs, and saves a real deliverable back to your folder.

The mental model that matters most: Cowork is about delegating, not just chatting. Chat is still incredibly powerful — it's where you'll go to think through problems, draft and refine, brainstorm, ask questions, and have Claude as a sounding board. Cowork doesn't replace any of that. What it adds is something new: the ability to hand Claude an entire piece of work — context, gathering, analysis, the production, tool use — and have it come back completed.

This is the single biggest shift for new Cowork users to make, and it's essential to really get this down. Most people's first instinct — coming from Chat — is to type a question, see what comes back, type a follow-up, and iterate. That works in Cowork too, but you'll get the most out of it when you reach for it for the work you'd normally do *yourself*, not the work you'd normally ask about.

But the differences between the two go even deeper than this. Mechanically, Chat is turn-by-turn. It can pull from your tools, but you stitch the steps together yourself. It is purpose-built for founded exchanges and quick thinking. Cowork, on the other hand, sustains a whole piece of work: it pulls from many tools at once, runs through multi-step plans, and returns the finished output. That's the gap uploads to Chat can't fully close.

You can see what makes a great Cowork task below.

ANATOMY OF A COWORK TASK

What did we decide about pricing last quarter? Look across the meeting notes in the Q3 Sales folder, my emails from the sales team, the leadership Slack, and the proposal decks — pull it all together and write me a one-page summary I can send to the exec team.

Click any underlined part of the prompt to see why this is Cowork's kind of work.

Click any underlined part of the prompt to see why this is Cowork's kind of work.

How Cowork works in your environment

Cowork works in your environment. Not adjacent to it.

- On your files — Claude reads what's in the folder you point it at, writes finished outputs back.
- In your apps — Claude pulls context from the email, calendar, messaging, drive, CRM you've connected.
- In your browser — for web tools that don't have a connector, Claude in Chrome reads and acts on the page itself: dashboards, portals, or anything behind a login.
- With your tools — Claude takes action, not just describes what to do.

Chat vs. Cowork vs. Code

Now that you know what Cowork is, take a moment to see how it fits alongside the other two ways you work with Claude on the desktop app.

The three modes are built for different shapes of work. Chat is turn-by-turn dialogue — quick exchanges, brainstorming, exploratory thinking, one tool at a time. Cowork is what you've just been reading about: a workspace where Claude reaches across many tools, sustains work over time, and produces finished outputs. Code is a full development environment that runs inside your codebase, with terminal and git access — built for developers writing and shipping software.

The interactive below has two parts: a three-way comparison so you can see all three at a glance, and a six-task challenge that asks you to pick the right mode for each scenario.

CHAT	COWORK	CODE
Thinking with Claude A conversation. You ask, draft, brainstorm, or think out loud — Claude responds in the chat window. BEST FOR • Asking questions and exploring ideas • Drafting something you'll refine yourself • Anything that fits in a single response	Delegating to Claude A workspace. Point Claude at a folder and your tools, describe an outcome — Claude plans, executes, and delivers. BEST FOR • Multi-step work across files and tools • Producing real deliverables (docs, decks, sheets) • Work you want to set in motion and come back to	Building software with Claude An agentic coding tool. Claude works inside a codebase — editing files, running tests, making commits. BEST FOR • Working in a repo • Building or refactoring across many source files • Deepening work, not document work

Match the task to the mode

For each task, pick the mode you'd reach for. We'll tell you why.

TASK 1 OF 6

"Read the five vendor PDFs in my Downloads folder, compare them on price and SLAs, and put the result in a spreadsheet."

Chat

Cowork

Code

FILE CHOSEN TO OFFLOAD

Next Task

To recap: Chat is for thinking with Claude. Cowork is for delegating to Claude. Code is for building software with Claude. Most knowledge workers will live in Chat and Cowork — and use them for very different things.

Lesson reflection

Think about a task you did recently where the value was in the doing, not just the thinking. Maybe it spanned multiple tools. Maybe it ended in a deliverable you assembled by hand. Maybe it's something you do every week that you'd love to leverage AI to handle for you.

Hold on to that task — you can come back to it in Lesson 3 when you start identifying your own Cowork use cases, and again in Lesson 4 when you delegate your first real task.

What's next

In the next lesson, you'll get Cowork set up: install the desktop app, point Claude at a working folder, add your first connectors, and learn the permissions model that keeps you in control of what Cowork can do.

Feedback

As you progress through the course, we'd love to hear how you're using concepts from it in your work, plus any feedback you may have. Share your feedback here.